

BE YOURSELF

Be yourself. I don't know how many of you consider advice as an act of kindness—but I do. Advice is a form of comfort when you need it the most. This is the story of my real life with some moments sculpted. Something I did so casually long before couldn't have returned to me at a better time than this—the return of a word at the most crucial time. Despite being a topper and a kind person, my communication skills with people weren't well-developed during my lower classes. It was one of my biggest weaknesses. Life was tough at that time. People I loved either moved to different cities or transferred schools. Those were the days before Corona, when we didn't have access to mobile phones or communication networks. Finding a household which had them was rare.

Time passed and I entered Class 9. Heavily affected by COVID—along with the world, my family too went through a difficult phase. My father lost his job, my grandfather passed away, and fights between my parents became common. Having no one to share things with, I fell into a pool of sadness. I was a lonely person. Until 10th, I was the small girl who stayed silent and would do her work. Marks were everything for me. Too focused on them, I forgot to look around and see what real life looked like—I realized that later. Exams were nearing, and preparations went on. The most anticipated days passed with immense hope of scoring high marks.

The most awaited day came—results were out. Frustration on one side, with tears rolling down my cheeks on the other. I got poor marks in Science while expecting 100. Shattered and crying—my first heartbreak. School reopened after 10 days. I felt pain and hated going to school. You may be wondering why this life story is going on—but the girl we will see in the later part had many similar incidents in her life, which made me say something I truly believed—and it showed up at the right time.

You know the typical scenario in Indian schools. Students who secure good marks get selected for school posts. All my heartbreaking events eventually led to my name being one among the selected for a post. The Assistant School Pupil Leader position was given to my friend, which she declined. To my surprise, the headmistress turned to me and asked. I thought, "Do I have the qualities?" I took a moment and said "Yes".

I was determined to improve myself—my character—me. That one yes is also a reason I haven't lost myself today. I got a teacher who taught life more than English and Chemistry. "Be yourself," she said. That stuck with me. It stayed with me most of the time. My perspectives started shifting. I began seeing life around me—good people, good experiences. I started building my life around that word—"Be Yourself". As I said earlier, I was very silent, but I overcame my fear of speaking. Having taken the second most reputed post in school, my biggest responsibility was organizing Teacher's Day. It went so well.

When teachers have their lunch, we captains take care of the whole school. That afternoon, we had fun, we talked. I casually went to the second floor to monitor classes. I entered a classroom. Juniors were always fun to talk to. They'd ask what

they should do. Whenever I advise someone, I usually tell them what *not* to do in life—how not to waste their time.

There was this small girl I remembered, sitting alone on the third bench. I had seen her many times before. She reflected me—small, yet very creative. Once, I read a story written by her for a competition. It was beautifully penned. That was all I knew about her. The thing about 8th standard little angels is that they get affected easily, attracted easily. It's not them—it's their hormones playing. Some people make fun of others, thinking those in front of them won't notice. When they grow up, they understand how badly they behaved. Some realize it, some don't. I don't exactly remember what happened, but during a casual conversation in that class, suddenly everyone started mocking that girl. They said a lot of nonsense about her. My friend and I were shocked. From 12-year-olds, we didn't expect that.

The girl being mocked looked very concerned but stayed silent. It impacted me. I wasn't very good at scolding or giving speeches to a class, so I asked my friend to handle the class while I called the girl outside. I asked her what happened. She suddenly started crying. That was when I realized—no matter the age, from a 4-year-old to a 90-year-old—people just need someone to ask and give them comfort. She had a short, heartbreaking family story. Her dad had passed away. Her mom worked far away. She stayed with her mom's sister, who always scolded her. I couldn't even listen to her story completely. Despite all this, she came to school, listened to lectures. She survived.

I was inspired.

I talked about my life, comforted her, and at last, I asked her to promise me one thing—

“Be yourself. Just because society is kicking you behind your back doesn't mean you have to change. It's them, not you.”

Someone came and called me, so I couldn't talk more. I saw a small smile on her face as I left. I was happy to see that. Later, there was a holiday. When I returned to school, I looked for her class—she wasn't there. Surprised, I asked a teacher. She said the girl had left the school and moved out of the city. I was shocked. I was deeply worried. But then years passed, and slowly, I forgot her. 11th passed. I wrote JEE—failed. I wrote 12th. Got placed in SSN. Life went on. Same problems, but I kept facing them—holding tightly to my policy of being *me*.

The first semester went well. When the second began, chaos started. I was a hosteller. People began competing with me for no reason. I helped them all, cleared their doubts, and of course, I studied—taking care of my mental and physical health. But people wanted to know every single thing I did, while hiding what they did from me. They'd go to the library and study in secret. I remained transparent—they didn't. They started acting behind my back, which I hated the most. Still, I remained silent and stayed away. The problem was—she was my roommate. I tried not to fight. But her actions got worse. My anger grew.

On one such day, I completely lost it. I was in utter rage. I promised myself I'd teach her a lesson. I started behaving like her—throwing things, doing nonsense in the room.

I don't know how time works, but this time—time saved me.

My phone rang. I picked up. A young voice said, "Akka, do you remember me?" In two years, I had heard many *akkas*, so I couldn't figure out who she was. She said, "Annaiku sonnogle? (You said that day, right?) I'm living on that promise." Suddenly, I recognized her voice. It was the same girl who had once cried to me.

My mind came back to reality. I realized—I was deviating from my path. A promise I had made... a promise she was still living by.

All my anger faded.

That moment reminded me of who I was—the real me. I reminded myself of my policy:

"Just keep calm, help others, and be yourself."

I reminded myself, **"Treat them as good as you are, not as bad as they are."** The asylum I needed came at the most important time. A smile developed automatically and I asked her, "What's your name?" She refused to tell me. She wanted to remain anonymous—but reminded me of *me*.

For one more time in life, I reminded myself- No, Life reminded me —**Be yourself.**